

## TO PARENTS FROM PARENTS



### FEEDING YOUR BABY

Parents often say that after worrying about their child's health, feeding their baby is the most stressful thing they deal with when coming home from the hospital. Babies born with heart conditions, especially those who had surgery, may have feeding issues and will need extra support. This is normal. Don't be afraid to get the help you need. Here are some helpful tips from parents:



#### EDUCATE YOURSELF

Knowledge is power. The more you can learn about your baby's CHD and any feeding and developmental issues that might come with it, the better prepared you will be and the more confident you will feel when making feeding decisions. If possible, before you leave the hospital, ask your child's nurses and doctor about educational resources.



#### GET SUPPORT

Feeding a baby with CHD can be very emotional, and parents can feel scared and overwhelmed. Build a support network. Start with health care providers who can help you with feeding issues. Ask your child's doctor and nurses if you don't know where to start. Family and friends can be helpful too. Also, there are many support groups of parents who have been through similar experiences that can provide support from someone who has been there.



#### FIND A QUIET PLACE

Find a quiet, peaceful place, if possible, to feed your baby. This may have been difficult in the hospital with all the noise and light, but when you get home, try to find a calm place to make feeding more enjoyable. This can help set a positive tone for feeding and reduce stress. Even if your baby has a feeding tube, you can still hold your baby in a quiet place. Feeding is a time to bond with your baby, and it is important to make it as pleasant as possible.



#### MANAGE STRESS

It can be very difficult not to feel stress about feeding your baby. Parents often worry about things like whether their baby is getting enough calories or having difficulty feeding. While getting enough calories is important, so is your stress level. Take care of yourself and find ways to manage stress. If you can, try to get enough sleep, eat well, take walks outside and exercise. This may seem impossible, but even if you can find small ways to manage stress, you will feel better and you may find feeding less stressful too.



#### FOLLOW YOUR INSTINCT

If you feel like something isn't right with your baby, talk to your child's health care team right away. Worst-case scenario, nothing is wrong, but it's far better to be wrong than to be right and not get help because you were worried about feeling embarrassed.



#### BE HAPPY WITH PROGRESS

Don't measure success by comparing your baby with other babies your child's age. It's easy to get caught up in a tangle of what your child "should be able to do." Focus instead on how your baby is improving and the positive things you have been able to achieve with your child's care. Every baby will progress in their own time. If you have questions about your baby's development, contact your child's health care team.

*Bringing a child home from the hospital can feel scary, and feeding can feel stressful. Get help if you need it. You can find more information and helpful tips on feeding your baby at [www.mendedhearts.org](http://www.mendedhearts.org).*